

making seriously sub standard products and flooding the market with them, and then disappearing or changing their company name when their products start failing, or worse, start causing damage to expensive phones and the like. The problem is that there are so many of them – you’ve obviously heard of Qi-certified wireless chargers, and we’ve mentioned MFi already. Then there are regional certifications needed, such as CE (Conformité Européene) for electrical devices to be sold in Europe and UL for certifications in 46 countries. India needs BIS certification (Bureau of Indian Standards) which will allocate

surveillance to happen for anyone. Once you give any agency the right to snoop on bad people, that opens up a Pandora’s box of essentially allowing that agency to snoop on anyone. All they need to do is convince themselves or a sympathetic judge, that just about anyone is “bad” and then snoop on them.

Leaving aside the uncomfortableness of trying to decide if your government or its agencies should be given the right to snoop, there’s also the question of what such backdoors into systems enable. Given that all systems are made and designed by humans, and there are always smarter humans around to

people were making plans on telegram to blow up a school bus full of kids, or would you leave that as a problem for the local police force and hope they are competent enough to prevent it from happening? Ed’s take on such surveillance is that it would all be done via bots anyway, flagging something concerning, and that all of us have privacy by default, just by hiding in plain sight, amongst a billion other people’s conversations. No one in the government cares if you’re cheating on your partner, because so are a million others. They do care if you’re looking up how to make a bomb though...

The rest of Team Digit fall somewhere in between these two extreme opinions, as perhaps, does most of the world. Coming back to manufacturers and brands though, and their pushback against the right to repair movement...

Brands often see the right to repair as them having to provide replacement parts and know-how to individuals who may or may not do a good job, which may or may not be in the individual’s best interests. For example, if a brand gives you an entire description of their product, (basically their internal manufacturing / repair documentation), that allows someone with enough knowledge (maybe even a competitor) to find a way to circumvent the security of their product, and thus, make their product worse. It also opens the doors for unscrupulous third parties to bypass security, or install something that does that, under the pretext of cheap repairs.

REFURBISHING

Any brand has a brand image to worry about. Even when refurbished products are being sold, a brand has the right to want its customers to have a good experience using their products. This is what the biggest brands cite as a huge reason for their opposition to the right to repair movement. Imagine you owned a brand called Pineapple, and were a market leader (globally) for a small set of products, which had gained the reputation of being high quality. Now, you are able to charge a premium for your Pineapple products because you have put in R&D, bought over companies, bought rights to use certain software, had chips designed and manufactured just for you,



Apple’s MFi is how they ensure that third party made devices live up to quality standards that are acceptable to Apple and its customers

the right certification based on the class of product.

As you can guess, certification is a legal nightmare, and anyone who has dabbled in manufacturing and exporting any type of product will attest to that. What we really need is a global standard, accepted by all countries, and all brand-enforced standards removed so that there can be no attempt at creating a monopoly or simple profiteering. However, attempting to attain world peace might be a more realistic goal at this point in time...

SECURITY

At a time when we hear about Pegasus and other hacking innovations that make a mockery of even the best systems that claim to secure your data on your devices, security seems like a very valid goal to aim for. What you do on your own device should be something no one else can snoop on, and this includes your family, governments, hackers, the company you bought the phone from, and pretty much anyone and any agency on Earth. “But what about terrorists?” is the first question to be thrown back at anyone who campaigns for total security. And to be honest, everyone knows that this is a slippery slope to tackle. Allowing surveillance to happen for terrorists, allows

bypass all securities put in place, leaving a backdoor into a system for use by, say, a government agency, also leaves that backdoor vulnerable to hackers and the like. Whether it’s foreign governments or just someone looking to hack your credit card information, a compromise in security is something none of us want.

This is a hotly debated topic of course, and the views vary in Team Digit itself, so we don’t want to falsely give the impression that this is somehow a settled argument. For instance our Paranoid Android (Mithun) is obviously against any form of backdoors, demanding perfection in security, and upholding the rights of us civilians as the most important aspect of security. Terrorists cannot be the reason to end security and privacy for ordinary people, in his opinion.

Ed (Robert), on the other hand holds the opinion that payments and financial information, and other such information that can be damaging and cause losses to individuals if they got into a hacker’s hands should be secured with military grade encryption and security, but sees no problems with allowing authorised agencies access to communications, for instance, in order to track and prevent terrorism or violence. Would you want to know if two crazy